

Incident Postmortem -- Auth Service Outage

Document Type: engineering | Incident: INC-2026-0419 | Severity: SEV1 | Date: 2026-02-27

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1. Incident Summary & Responders

Incident Commander: Rachel Okonkwo -- rachel.okonkwo@aexp.com -- (480) 555-0191

Primary On-Call (Auth): Sameer Patel -- sameer.patel@aexp.com -- (480) 555-0124

Comms Lead: Tony Briggs -- tony.briggs@aexp.com -- (212) 555-0188

Incident INC-2026-0419 (SEV1) caused a 47-minute partial outage of the cardmember authentication service on 2026-02-26, 14:12-14:59 ET. Approximately 6.2% of login attempts failed during the window.

2. Root Cause

A configuration change to the OAuth token-signing service deployed a rotated signing key without propagating the public key to all validation nodes. Validation nodes in the us-east region rejected tokens signed with the new key, producing HTTP 401 responses for affected sessions.

The change passed staging because the staging cluster shares a single key-distribution node, masking the propagation gap that exists in the multi-region production topology.

3. Resolution & Action Items

Mitigation: rolled back the key rotation at 14:51 ET; full recovery by 14:59 ET. Action items: (1) add a cross-region key-propagation health check to the deploy pipeline -- owner Sameer Patel, due 2026-03-13; (2) require a canary in a multi-node validation cluster before production rollout -- owner Rachel Okonkwo, due 2026-03-20; (3) add alerting on 401-rate deltas per region -- owner Tony Briggs, due 2026-03-06.